
Animated, Live Action, or AI?

By Elmir Shabayev, Arya Sukarno, George Cook, Alex
Chuang



Table of contents

01

Research Question

02

Experiment Design

03

Experiment Results
& Analysis

04

Studio Implications

The Studio Dilemma

Studios are creating live action adaptations:

Industry Options for Adaptations:

Example:



Animated

Real Live-Action

AI-Generated Live-Action



The Studio Dilemma

To help Studios decide on an adaptation to avoid high costs, we designed an experiment to find out which format actually drives the highest viewer intent!



01

The Research Question



Research Question



Research Question 1

Does the “live-action” component of remakes increase consumers’ intent to watch?



Research Question 2

Does the “live action” being AI generated drives different engagement levels?

Hypothesis



Research Question 1

H_0 : There is no difference in favorability between live-action and animated posters.

H_1 : Live-action posters will be rated less favorably than animated posters.



Research Question 2

H_0 : There is no difference in favorability between AI-generated and animated posters.

H_1 : AI-generated posters will be rated less favorably than animated posters.

02

The Experiment



Experimental Design: Treatment Arms

Control Group

Original animated posters
— anime style and western
cartoons .



Arm 1: Live-Action

Professionally produced
live-action posters of the
same franchises.



Arm 2: AI-Generated

AI-generated live-action
posters depicting the same
franchises.



Experimental Design

Randomization

Simple individual randomization via Qualtrics.

Outcome Measure

Click-to-watch rating on a 0–10 scale per poster to measure if people would watch the show..

Timed Poster Viewing

Respondents could only see the posters for 15 seconds so that they do not focus on specific poster poses or characteristics.

Pre-Treatment Characteristics Collected

Online via Qualtrics, April 2026. 115 respondents, mostly aged 18–24. Post-treatment questions measured demographics and media habits as covariates.

Randomization Check



Proportions Z-Test

102 balance tests run across demographics, platform usage, and media habits. Only 2 returned $p < 0.05$ — consistent with chance variation. OLS regression confirmed zero covariates were imbalanced across all 102 tests.



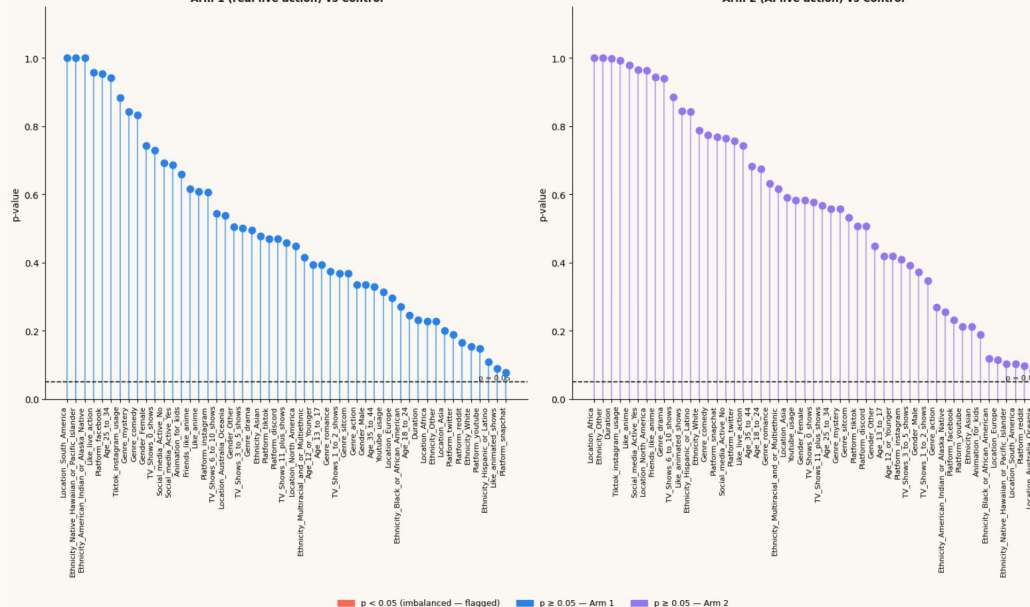
OLS Regression Check

102 regressions regressed each covariate on treatment indicators. No single covariate reached $p < 0.05$. Groups are well-balanced — randomization was successful.

Randomization Check — Regression-Based p-values per Covariate
(each covariate regressed on treatment dummies)

Arm 1 (real live action) vs Control

Arm 2 (AI live action) vs Control



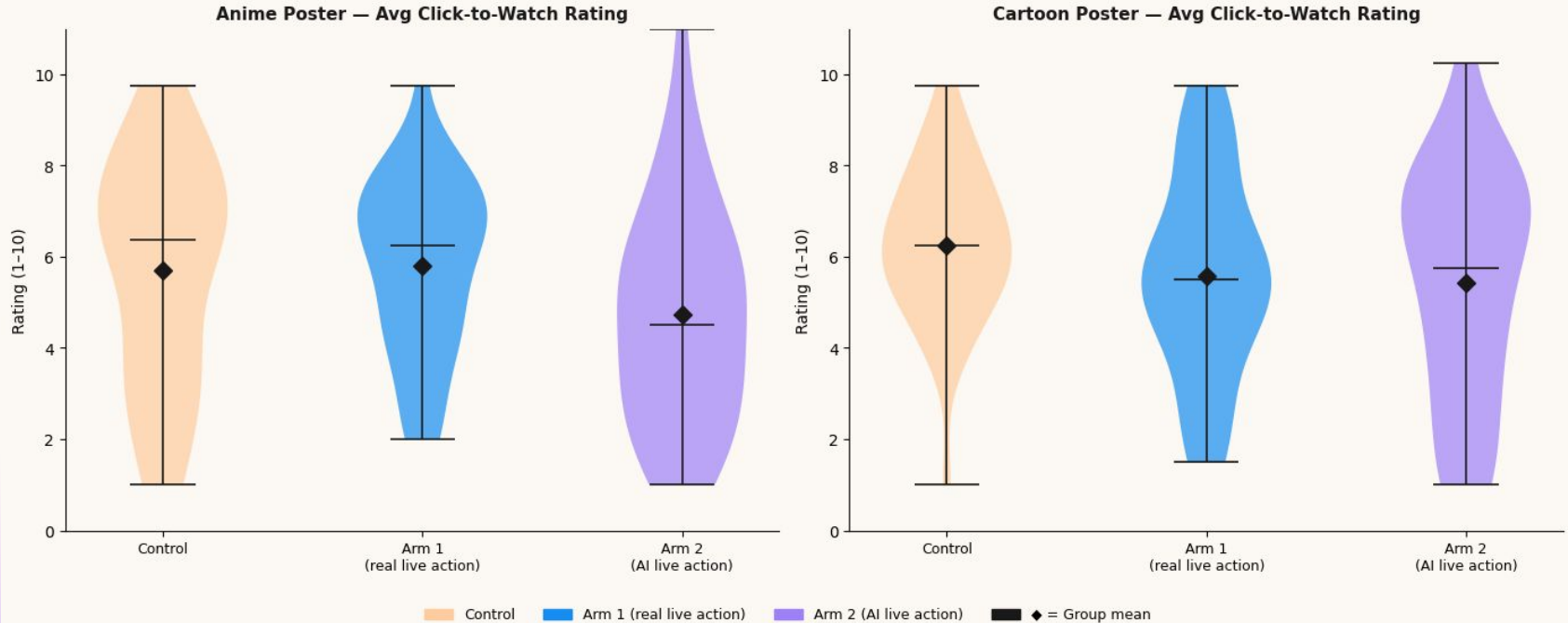
03

Experiment

Results & Analysis



Outcome Distribution by Experimental Group



Regression & Covariate Results

Group	Anime Rating	Cartoon Rating	Anime vs. Control	Cartoon vs. Control
Control (Animated)	5.71	6.26	—	—
Arm 1 (Live-Action)	5.81	5.59	+0.10	-0.67
Arm 2 (AI-Generated)	4.72	5.44	-0.99*	-0.82*
Arm 1 w/ Covariates	—	—	+0.20	-0.78*
Arm 2 w/ Covariates	—	—	-1.60***	-1.27**
Significance: * $p < 0.10$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$				



AI: -1.6 pts

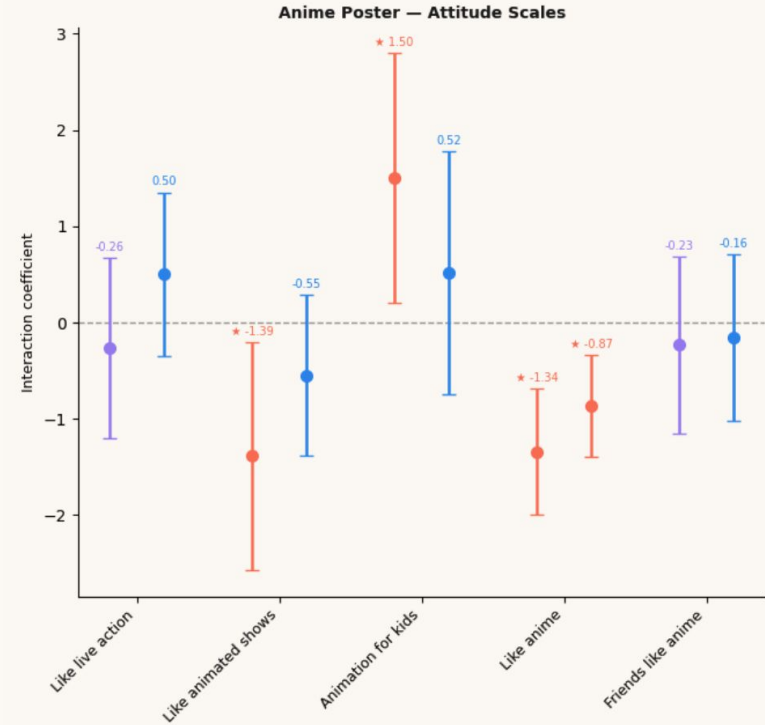
The most striking finding: AI-generated live-action posters reduced anime click-to-watch intent by 1.6 points ($p < 0.01$) after controlling for demographics and media habits.

Who Is Affected Most?

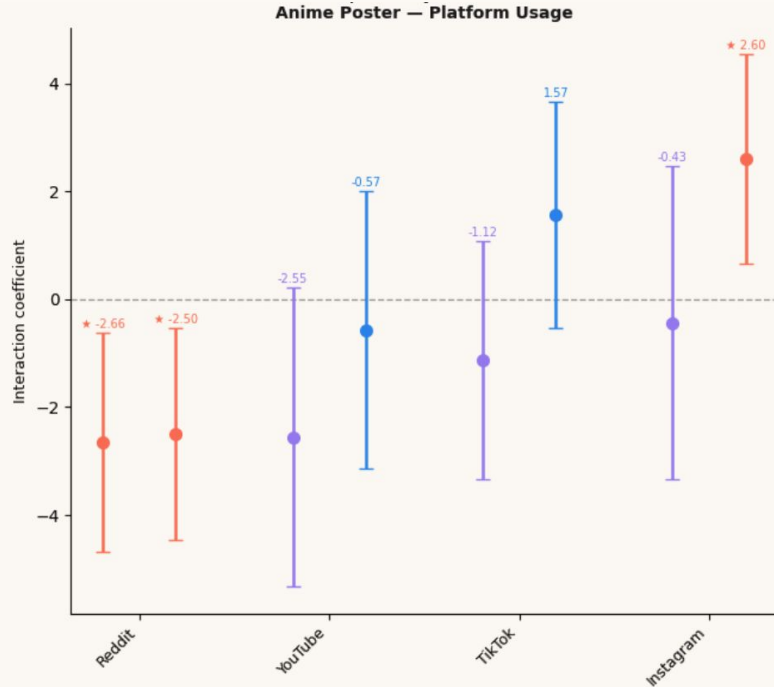


Anime Fans

- Respondents who “Like Anime” rated live-action adaptations significantly more harshly.
- Interaction $\beta = -1.34$ ($p < 0.01$) for AI arm.
- Existing fans are most resistant to format changes.



Who Is Affected Most?



Platform Users

- Instagram users showed a +2.60 interaction for live-action ($p < 0.01$).
- Respond more positively to real live-action adaptations.
- Reddit users have very negative opinions on either adaptation.
 - Almost rated live action as low as AI.

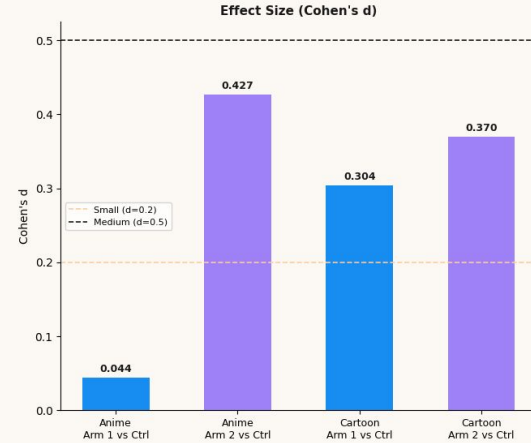
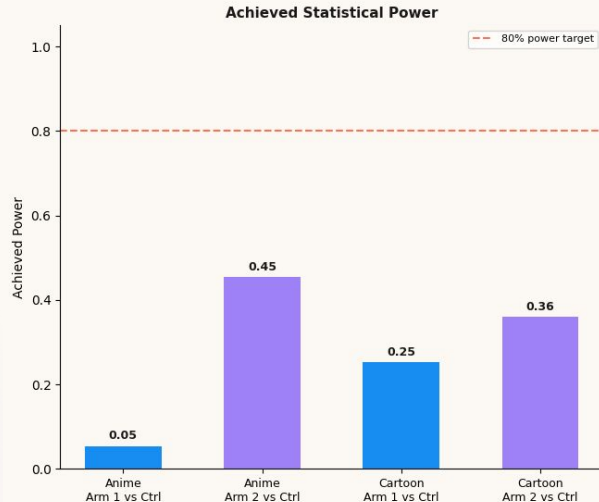
Statistical Power & Effect Sizes

Anime, Live Action vs. Control:

- Near-zero. Live-action vs. animated: no significant difference detected.

Cartoon, Live Action vs. Control:

- Moderate Effect, indicating some effect in cartoon live action versions of western cartoons.



Anime, AI vs Control:

- Strongest effect. Needs ~90 respondents/group for 80% power. AI posters significantly reduce anime watch intent.

Cartoon, AI vs Control:

- Cohen's $d = 0.378$, Power = 0.353. Moderate effect. AI-generated posters also reduce cartoon intent, significant after adding covariates ($p < 0.05$).

04

Studio Implications



Limitations & Next Steps

Sample Size

Only 115 respondents (~38/group). Underpowered for small effects. Most comparisons fell below the 0.80 power threshold. Null results may reflect insufficient sample size.

Media Biases

Each category was limited to 4 pieces of media. These 4 may not be representative of all perceptions of their medium.

Poster Quality

AI poster quality may not match professionally produced material. Without rigorous quality validation, this arm may not represent realistic AI promotional content.

Generalizability

Sample skewed 18–24 (84%). Only examined show posters. Intent-to-watch may not translate to true viewership.

Conclusions for Studies

Main Takeaway

AI-generated live action content is clearly disliked.

Fans prefer original animation over live-action.

Future Research

Larger samples, real viewing behavior metrics, and varied AI quality needed for future work.

Conclusions for Studies

Recommendations

Keep it animated for existing fans — format loyalty is strong among anime and cartoon audiences

Target Instagram for live-action campaigns — visual-platform users respond well to real live-action

Avoid AI-generated content in current promotional materials — audiences detect and reject it



Thank you!

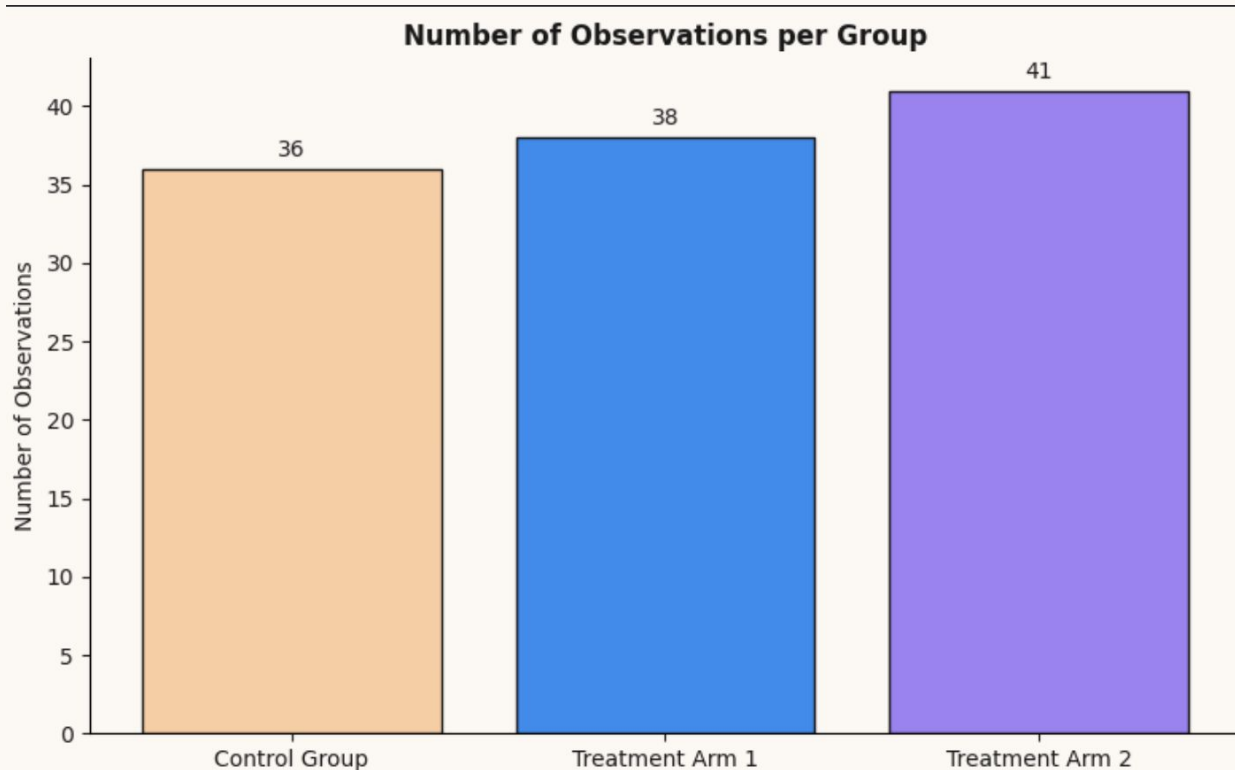
Any questions?



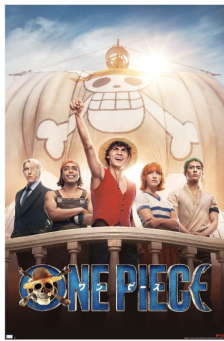
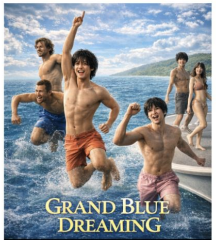
Appendix

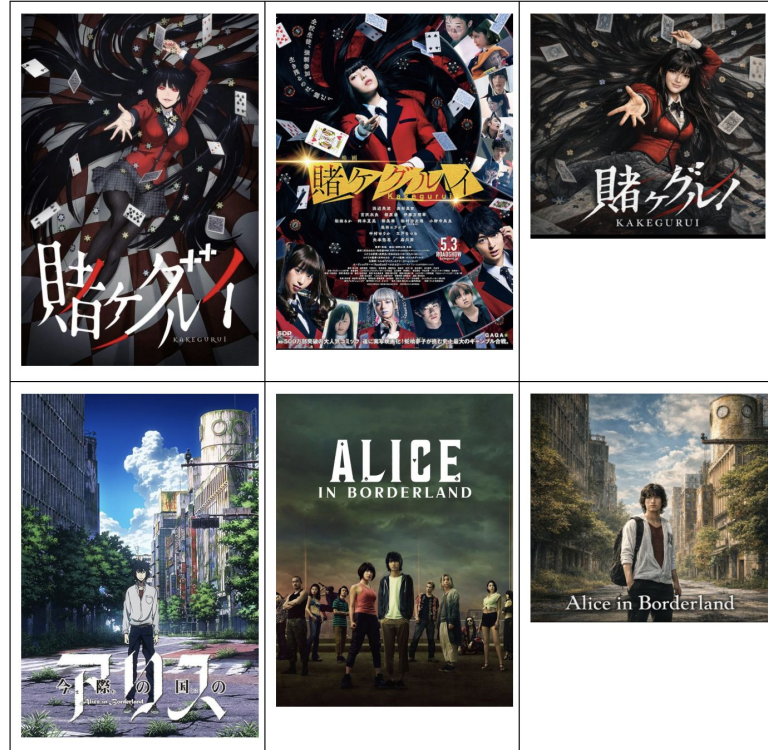


Number of participants in each group.



Anime Posters

Anime/Animation	Live Action	AI Generated
		
		



Cartoon Posters

